

AI for Sustainability

Posted by u/franciscrot • 0 points • 6 comments

I've been hearing a lot recently about how AI can contribute to environmental sustainability. On the other hand, AI itself comes with an environmental cost. The real use cases for AI also are hard to sort out from the hype.

Have you come across effective uses of AI for sustainability? And / or claims that sound too good to be true?

How do you see things developing in the future?

Also, someone recently suggested it might be a nice idea to have a collaborative doc where we collect claims about AI for sustainability, and do some research into those claims. So I've done that:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1il-9wKrqsv4RZtnyVjA-cv_nCxXW3VbEjtm1Tb4EBx8/edit?usp=drivesdk

Please feel free to contribute / share.

Comments

u/big_map_small_world • 1 points • 2026-03-29 00:16 UTC

I work in sustainability auditing. A lot of my work is domain-based knowledge work. However, a significant portion is tedious repeatable tasks would could easily be automated. Has anyone developed AI tools for similar use?

u/ApprehensiveAd8737 • 1 points • 2025-08-26 23:37 UTC

Additionally, the collective document focuses solely on environmental sustainability, but there are significant threats to society that will have substantial environmental impacts.

u/entropy-ch • 1 points • 2025-03-11 07:39 UTC

AI can drive tangible sustainability gains by optimizing energy usage and streamlining resource management. However, the benefits must be weighed against the environmental cost of running the technology itself. While some claims seem exaggerated, real-world implementations are demonstrating

measurable improvements.

Checkout omdena.com if this got you thinking.

u/SACtrades • 1 points • 2025-01-22 05:29 UTC

This is the future

u/GrowthDreamer • 2 points • 2025-01-14 11:55 UTC

As someone, who has spoken to several founders in this sustainability + AI space, here's my take-

1. A generic AI + sustainability product won't succeed. Need to be hyper-specific about what's being solved.

2. With the term AI- there's still a perception of the unknown and an element of threat- so doesn't make sense to go with AI focussed marketing. Outcome focussed marketing makes more sense.

3. With the cost of content creation going to zero, the premium on Context and relationships has grown 10x. Thus a standalone self-serve/performance marketing funnel won't work in most cases. Having a services/partnerships team will generate a lot of value.

4. Additionally, think deeply if an AI is actually needed- because the companies using such products care a lot about data privacy and security- and several of those certifications/processes are costly.

Happy to have a longer conversation, if you are building something in this domain :)

u/ApprehensiveAd8737 • 1 points • 2025-08-26 23:34 UTC

great points, especially #4 and #2. At this point, it may be less important to create an AI product for sustainability, particularly if one is developing an AI product for its own sake. It's worth thinking deeply about the "Why?" And why not focus on the risk that it poses instead?

u/MyMatR • 1 points • 2025-01-13 15:26 UTC

AI definitely has value for sustainability. It's being used in tools that optimize waste management, energy grids, water, etc. All of which would allow for more sustainable and smarter uses of resources. Of course the negative environmental consequences of AI are present, but I believe we can make AI models more energy-efficient without sacrificing capability. Its important to find a balance between innovation and responsibility.

u/CuppaMatt • 2 points • 2025-01-13 09:23 UTC

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See Also: Oil Drilling for Enviromentalism, Turning the heater on for cooling down, etc

u/Upstairs-File4220 • 1 points • 2025-01-13 06:30 UTC

I think carbon capture tech powered by AI is still in the hype phase. It sounds great, but I haven't seen a solid, scalable solution yet. On the other hand, AI's role in grid management, optimizing energy distribution, is a real and promising area. That tech is getting stronger every year.

u/franciscrot • 1 points • 2025-01-15 22:03 UTC

Any good case studies or other leads for the grid management stuff

u/Upstairs-File4220 • 1 points • 2025-01-16 07:50 UTC

Definitely! Look into NextEra's grid projects, they're implementing AI to manage renewable energy loads. Pretty exciting stuff!

u/franciscrot • 1 points • 2025-01-24 13:43 UTC

Will check out NextEra, thanks :)

u/PanflightsGuy • 1 points • 2025-01-13 01:16 UTC

I asked Bing's Copilot for more sustainable travel search engines - sites offering real emission cuts and not offsets, or "below average emissions" badges.

Typically offsetting sites come up in traditional search engines when searching for reduced emission trips.

But Copilot suggested a site that replaces indirect flights with e.g. direct flight + train combos. Meaning travel will still be swift enough, but with effective emission cuts.

u/thx1138inator • 2 points • 2025-01-12 21:52 UTC

Not all models are the same. The ones where the questions or tasks are very broad, necessitate a very large model which costs a lot of CPU to train. More domain specific tasks can be trained on much smaller, more efficient models.

u/time4abirdtofly • 4 points • 2025-01-12 20:57 UTC

I have had some experience with Fingreen AI. It's a sustainability tool that works really well for CSRD and other corporate sustainability reporting. The unnecessary use of AI like you see on Facebook is wasteful but when used effectively is a great tool to gather information more efficiently.